

After he's seen the rest, Boston feels like the best

How does it feel, everyone asks, to be back in Boston after two months driving around the United States?

What feels best is the blast of shivery air that greets you when you open the front door. After coming back through the Sunbelt, every pore feels alive for the first time in weeks. I feel confirmed in a deep conviction that all civilization arises from chill and that nothing worthwhile will ever emerge from Phoenix.

Anyway, what follows is a collection of completely random impressions of a trip through Bicentennial America.

First, the Strips—how beautiful they are in the West. Here in the East, the commercial highway Strips around our old cities always seem to be rows of fake plastic-and-neon fronts on otherwise decaying Victorian mansions. They're gaudy glitter and rouge on an atrophying corpse. But Gallup, N. Mex., is something else. Its Strip is shiny and fresh, all new. And it's all there is—surrounded by desert and void. A sudden flash of plumage on the horizon, it isn't schlock; it's heroic and pathetic, the brave planting of bright flags on a moon, a sign of human life. Especially at night on the black desert, the first glimpse of all those frozen neon fireworks rising over the horizon is moving and beautiful.

As you get closer, the unbelievable complexity of massed, multi-colored signs and shapes—always foreshortened, compressed into a collage since you approach the Strip endwise—has a Cubist complexity. Unfortunately, the Strip always turns out to be a lot less interesting than beautiful. The incredible Gallup strip, which must be 15 miles long, is just a staccato repetition of more or less interchangeable motels, gas stations, and junk food counters.

San Francisco—how discordant it can make Boston look. It's because all the buildings are painted different shades of white that they pile up so successfully on the hills into those great white clusters. They agglomerate. Historians say the city's fashions changed from cool blue-gray to warmer creams and ochres around 1915, when, at the Panama-Pacific Exposition, the great Bernard Maybeck's wonderful burnt-ochre stucco palace of Fine Arts arose, reflected in green pools of water. (The second Carter-Ford debate was held in it, but did the networks fill us in on Maybeck? Do fish ride bicycles? As someone pointed out, Jefferson was the last President who had even the slightest acquaintance with architecture.)

Another of San Francisco's unique qualities comes from the hills. They make the city visible to itself; you're always looking across to hills, or down from hills. Parts of the city stay in visual touch with each other, feel like parts of the same place. There's no Southie, no Charlestown isolated from the rest.

Since Haight-Ashbury, it's been trendy to violate the overall whiteness by the "Victorians" — the old bay-win-

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dowed houses — in the manner of circus wagons, using a different color for every patch of surface and trim. Such houses can be stunning individually but they don't always agglomerate so well. A lot of them use "color consultants" to get that just-right combination of mauve and mustard. (Is this a new field for underemployed architects?)

The sense of a public life, a civic forum, is stronger in San Francisco than in any other American city—there are surely more bars, more restaurants, more bookstores, more people out enjoying city life. Of course a lot of them are tourists, but in the great cities a lot of them always were. Coming back to Boston, our first visit was to Faneuil Markets and it was great to feel that same sense of people flocking to enjoy the city together.

Los Angeles. I read the book on Los Angeles by Rayner Banham on the way out and got enthused. But Banham's book turns out to be just another in that endless series of reverse-snob books by Englishmen glorifying one or another aspect of the American Noble Savage. L.A. is still a drag, still like all those cop shows on TV in which all the characters seem to spend all their time opening and closing the doors of large automobiles. In L.A., since everywhere to go is boring, the act of travel, which is smooth and snarl-free, becomes life's joy. Certainly nowhere in the city is there a real sense of forum, of people coming together, overlapping, reacting with one another.

San Simeon, William Randolph Hearst's silly movie-style castle was made memorable by one of those inanely sexist guides who ushered our tour group around saying things like, "The ladies will especially enjoy this next room." The next room always turned out to boast something frilly such as tapestries. Yet San Simeon was built by a woman, the engineer-architect Julia Morgan. And the medieval tapestries were made by men.

Frank Lloyd Wright. How striking is the butcher-built quality of his two homes, Taliesin East in Wisconsin and Taliesin West in Arizona. Both radiate the sense, proper to any environment but more usual on those not "designed," of a place constantly in a state of repair and improvisation, forever to be patched and adapted—as indeed they are, both having been built mostly by student apprentices over a period of decades and still in progress. A lot is done with plywood and scraps, and nothing ever looks so finished that you'd feel intimidated about changing it. And the raggedness weaves the buildings easily into the landscape.

Buffalo, N.Y., where I grew up. How different it looks in scale, in its sense of space, since the elm trees disappeared; how astonishingly successful they were in creating urban spaces, vistas, boulevards where the architecture, now left to itself, fails. How often today do we pay as much attention to landscape as the people who, around the turn of the century, planted a half million elm trees in Buffalo?